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ARDUPILOT PYTHON SIMULATOR

Figure-8 Tracking with ArduCopter-4.7.1 and 3DR IRIS in Python

Fly your algorithm against ArduPilot in Python before you fly it for real.



Figure 1: ArduPilot Figure-Eight Drone Simulation.png

This notebook flies a simulated drone through a figure-8 under the control of ArduPilot:

- **Firmware:** ArduPilot **ArduCopter Copter-4.7.1**. Its position, attitude and rate controllers and its motor mixer are ported line by line to Python, with the stock parameter names and defaults, and fly in `GUIDED` mode.

- **Drone:** the **3DR Iris** quadcopter (1.5 kg, quad-X), with mass, inertia and rotor data from the Gazebo `iris.sdf` model. Its flight controller is a **Pixhawk** board, which carries the IMU and runs the ArduCopter firmware.
- **Mission:** take off to $5\,m$, fly one *figure-8* (∞), $8\,m$ east–west by $4\,m$ north–south, in about $63\,s$, then return to the origin and land. A companion-computer script streams the reference to the autopilot as MAVLink position targets.
- **Wind sweep:** the same mission flown 24 more times, in a constant wind of 4, 8 and 12 m/s from 8 compass directions, to see how the stock tuning holds up in wind. The flights are independent and run in parallel, one per CPU core.
- **C4DYNAMICS:** true drone dynamics, pixhawk sensors, rigidbody models.

> ⚠️ **Disclaimer: no $EKF3$.** ArduPilot's state estimator, $EKF3$, is **not** ported. The flight controller flies on the vehicle's *true* attitude, position and velocity (with optional white noise), not on a solution fused from IMU, GPS, compass and barometer. Estimation errors, filter lag, GPS glitches and innovation-gate behaviour are therefore absent, and the tracking results in Section 5 are a best case: on a real vehicle, expect larger position errors.

For a hand-written 3-loop cascade PID flies a *figure-8* (∞) see Quadcopter Cascade-PID example,

Goal

1. Build a closed loop of *companion computer* → *ArduPilot* → *vehicle* in which ArduPilot runs its real control law, with its real parameter names and defaults.
2. Fly the *figure-8* in `GUIDED` mode and evaluate how well the stock ArduCopter tuning tracks it on a 3DR Iris airframe.
3. Use the simulator the way it is meant to be used: change an ArduPilot parameter and see the effect before going to the field.
4. Run a statistical experiment that a single test flight cannot: sweep the wind speed and direction and find where the tuning runs out of margin.

Table of Contents

1. Introduction
2. Dynamics
3. Sensors
4. Main Loop
5. Results
6. Wind Sweep
7. Summary

1. Introduction

1.1. Setup

```
import sys
# On Google Colab, install c4dynamics -- it ships this example's
ArduPilot port too.
# Pin >=2.6.0: this notebook uses quatbody, eqm.quadeqm and the
ArduPilot port,
# introduced in that release.
if 'google.colab' in sys.modules:
    !pip install -q "c4dynamics>=2.6.0"

# joblib runs the wind sweep of Section 6 in parallel
(preinstalled on Colab and Anaconda)
try:
    import joblib
except ImportError:
    %pip install -q joblib

import numpy as np
import c4dynamics as c4d
assert tuple(map(int, c4d.__version__.split('.')[:2])) >= (2,
6), (
        f'this notebook needs c4dynamics >= 2.6.0, found
{c4d.__version__}')
from matplotlib import pyplot as plt
from scipy.integrate import solve_ivp

from c4dynamics.utils.use_cases import ardupilot, pixhawk
```

- Two supporting files hold the flight controller: the ArduCopter port, ardupilot — the “firmware” of this simulation — and the board it runs on, pixhawk, which carries the sensors.

- Everything else — the vehicle dynamics, the main loop, the plots — is written in this notebook.

1.2. ArduPilot in the Loop

On a real drone, two computers fly the vehicle: - A flight controller (required) that keeps the vehicle stable and on target. - A Companion computer (optional) that runs the mission and commands the autopilot.

In addition, the vehicle itself carries the computers, the motors, and the physical properties.

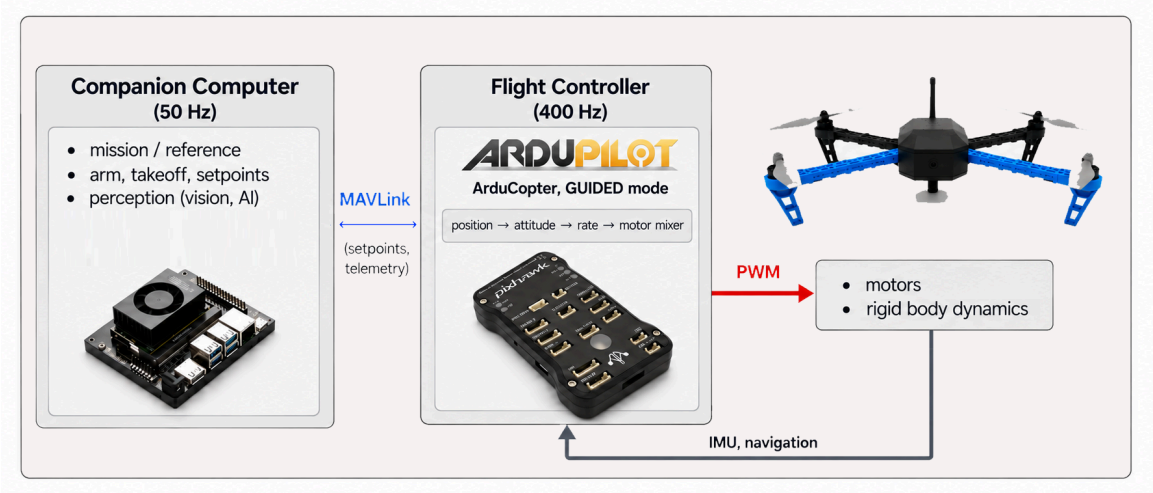


Figure 2: architecture.png

This simulation keeps this split, and each block is a separate object in the main loop:

Block	File	Rate
Companion computer	• this notebook: main loop — figure-8 reference. - MAVLink-like calls. - sends position / velocity / acceleration targets in NED (`SET_POSITION_TARGET_LOCAL_NED`).	50 Hz
Flight controller	• pixhawk: the board and its sensors. - ardupilot: the firmware. - reads an IMU sample and a navigation solution and returns four PWM values.	400 Hz

Block	File	Rate
Vehicle	• 3DR Iris model: a quatbody with motors	400 Hz

1.3. The ArduCopter Port

The flight controller is a line-by-line Python port of the ArduPilot libraries that fly a multicopter in `GUIDED` mode. Function names and parameter names follow the C++ source, so the two can be read side by side.

ArduPilot library	Role	Main parameters
`AC_PosControl`	position (sqrt-P) → velocity (PID) → acceleration; vertical: acceleration (PID) → throttle	`PSC_*`, `WP_SPD*`, `WP_ACC*`
`AC_AttitudeControl_Multi`	thrust vector + heading → quaternion attitude error → body-rate target; body-rate $PIDs$	`ATC_*`
`AP_MotorsMatrix`	roll / pitch / yaw / throttle → four motor outputs (quad X), thrust linearisation, PWM	`MOT_*`
`AC_PID`, `AP_Math`	the PID family, square-root controller, jerk-limited kinematic shaping	

The fast loop runs in the same order as `ArduCopter/Copter.cpp`:

```
read IMU -> rate controller -> motors output -> read AHRS ->
flight mode (position + attitude control)
```

so the rate PIDs act on the body-rate target computed one tick earlier, as on the real vehicle.

State estimation is not ported. instead of running $EKF3$, the $AHRS$ takes the navigation solution from the simulator (Section 3). Spool-up ramps,

notch filters, battery compensation and terrain following are also left out. Takeoff and landing are simplified versions of ArduCopter's.

The flight controller is created with its default parameters. Any ArduPilot parameter can be overridden by name, exactly as in a `.param` file:

```
copter = ardupilot.ArduCopter()

print(f"{len(copter.params)} parameters, e.g.:")
for name in ['SCHED_LOOP_RATE', 'ATC_ANG_PIT_P',
'ATC_RAT_PIT_P', 'ATC_RAT_PIT_I', 'ATC_RAT_PIT_D',
             'PSC_NE_POS_P', 'PSC_NE_VEL_P', 'PSC_D_ACC_P',
'MOT_THST_EXPO', 'MOT_THST_HOVER']:
    print(f"  {name:16s} = {copter.params[name]}")
```

```
87 parameters, e.g.:
  SCHED_LOOP_RATE  = 400
  ATC_ANG_PIT_P    = 4.5
  ATC_RAT_PIT_P    = 0.135
  ATC_RAT_PIT_I    = 0.135
  ATC_RAT_PIT_D    = 0.0036
  PSC_NE_POS_P     = 1.0
  PSC_NE_VEL_P     = 2.0
  PSC_D_ACC_P      = 0.05
  MOT_THST_EXPO    = 0.65
  MOT_THST_HOVER   = 0.35
```

Edit the dictionary to try your own values (an unknown name raises an error, so typos do not pass silently):

```
ardupilot_params = {
    # e.g. 'ATC_RAT_PIT_P': 0.2,
}
```

2. Dynamics

2.1. Frames

This example uses ArduPilot's conventions throughout the vehicle and the flight controller:

- Earth frame NED: x north, y east, z down.
- Body frame FRD: x forward, y right, z down.

The companion computer keeps the figure-8 in ENU (x east, y north, z up), as in the Cascade-PID example, and converts to NED when it sends a target (Section 4) — the same place MAVROS or a companion script does it.

2.2. Rigid Body

The vehicle is a quatbody, a rigid body whose attitude is a unit quaternion, with the 13-state vector

$$\mathbf{x} = \begin{bmatrix} x & y & z & v_x & v_y & v_z & q_w & q_x & q_y & q_z & p & q & r \end{bmatrix}^T$$

position and velocity in NED $[m, m/s]$, the attitude quaternion (scalar first) and FRD body rates $[rad/s]$.

Translational dynamics.

Thrust T acts along $-z$ of the body, linear drag opposes the body velocity $\mathbf{v}_b = [BI] \cdot \mathbf{v}$:

$$\mathbf{F}_b = \begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ 0 \\ -T \end{bmatrix} - \begin{bmatrix} A_x u \\ A_y v \\ A_z w \end{bmatrix}$$

$$\dot{\mathbf{v}} = \frac{[BI]^T \cdot \mathbf{F}_b}{m} + \begin{bmatrix} 0 & 0 & g \end{bmatrix}^T$$

where $[BI]$ is the body-from-inertial DCM of the quaternion (quat2dcm).

Rotational dynamics.

Euler's equations with rotor moments $\boldsymbol{\tau}$ and rotational damping A_r:

$$I\dot{\boldsymbol{\omega}} = \boldsymbol{\tau} - A_r\boldsymbol{\omega} - \boldsymbol{\omega} \times I\boldsymbol{\omega}, \qquad \boldsymbol{\omega} = [p, q, r]^T$$

and the quaternion kinematics

$$\begin{aligned}
\dot{q}_w &= -\frac{1}{2}(q_x p + q_y q + q_z r), \\
\dot{q}_x &= \frac{1}{2}(q_w p + q_y r - q_z q), \\
\dot{q}_y &= \frac{1}{2}(q_w q - q_x r + q_z p), \\
\dot{q}_z &= \frac{1}{2}(q_w r + q_x q - q_y p)
\end{aligned}$$

The quaternion is renormalized to unit length after every step.

Ground. The vehicle cannot go below $z = 0$: while it rests on the ground, the ground carries its weight.

These equations, with the rotor model of Section 2.3, are c4dynamics' quadcopter model quadeqm, the same model the Cascade-PID and EKF examples fly.
`frame='NED'` selects the NED / FRD convention used here, and the 13-state vector selects the quaternion form.

2.3. Motors

ArduPilot numbers the motors of a quad X as follows (top view):

```
<img src="m_01_01_quad_x.svg" alt="Quadcopter" width="250">
```

Each rotor i at body position (x_i, y_i) produces thrust $F_i = k_T\Omega_i^2$ and reaction torque $k_Q\Omega_i^2$, with spin direction $d_i = +1$ for CCW, -1 for CW:

$$T = \sum F_i, \qquad \boldsymbol{\tau} = \begin{bmatrix} -\sum y_i F_i \\ \sum x_i F_i \\ \sum d_i k_Q \Omega_i^2 \end{bmatrix}$$

ESC and motor.
The flight controller outputs PWM (Pulse Width Modulation). The ESC (Electronic Speed Controller) maps it to a normalized command $u = (PWM - 1000)/1000$, the motor starts producing thrust above u_{min} (spin-min) and saturates at u_{max} (spin-max).
Within that range the thrust follows the quadratic curve ArduPilot assumes (`MOT_THST_EXPO`, $a = 0.65$):

$$e = \frac{u - u_{min}}{u_{max} - u_{min}}, \qquad \frac{F}{F_{max}} = (1 - a)\, e + a\, e^2$$

The rotor speed follows its command through a first-order lag, faster spinning up than down.

2.4. Vehicle Parameters

The airframe is the 3DR Iris, with mass, inertia and rotor data from the Gazebo `iris.sdf` model (see iris_quadcopter.py). Rotor positions are given in FRD, in ArduPilot's motor order:

```
iris = {
    'm'         : 1.5,         # mass [kg]
    'g'         : 9.80665,     # gravity [m/s^2]
    'Ixx'       : 0.0347563,   # roll inertia [kg.m^2]
    'Iyy'       : 0.0458929,   # pitch inertia [kg.m^2]
    'Izz'       : 0.0977,      # yaw inertia [kg.m^2]
    'kT'       : 8.5485e-6,  # thrust coefficient [N/(rad/s)^2]
    'kQ'      : 1.6e-7,     # torque coefficient [N.m/(rad/s)^2]
    'omega_max': 838.0,       # max rotor speed [rad/s]
    'tau_up'   : 0.0125,      # motor spin-up time constant [s]
    'tau_down' : 0.025,      # motor spin-down time constant [s]
    'rotor_pos': np.array([[ 0.13,  0.22],    # motor 1  front-
right  [m] (x fwd, y right)
                           [-0.13, -0.20],    # motor 2  rear-left
                                   [ 0.13, -0.22],     # motor 3
front-left
```

```
                                    [-0.13,  0.20]]),  # motor 4
rear-right
    'rotor_dir': np.array([1, 1, -1, -1]),    # +1 CCW, -1 CW
    'thrust_expo': 0.65,     # thrust curve
    'spin_min' : 0.15,       # ESC command where thrust starts
   'spin_max' : 0.95,      # ESC command where thrust saturates
    'Ax'       : 0.30,       # linear drag, body x [N/(m/s)]
    'Ay'       : 0.30,       # linear drag, body y [N/(m/s)]
    'Az'       : 0.25,       # linear drag, body z [N/(m/s)]
    'Ar'      : 0.002,     # rotational damping [N.m/(rad/s)]
}

F_max = iris['kT'] * iris['omega_max']**2
print(f"max thrust per motor {F_max:.2f} N | thrust-to-weight
{4 * F_max / (iris['m'] * iris['g']):.2f} "
       f"| hover thrust fraction {iris['m'] * iris['g'] / (4
* F_max):.3f}")
```

```
max thrust per motor 6.00 N | thrust-to-weight 1.63 | hover
thrust fraction 0.613
```

The Iris hovers at about 61% of its maximum thrust — a heavy, low-margin vehicle. ArduCopter's default `MOT_THST_HOVER` is 0.35; the autopilot learns the true value in flight (Section 5).

2.5. The Vehicle Model

`QuadPlant` *is* the vehicle: a quatbody that carries the airframe parameters and the four rotor speeds. `step` advances it by one time step under constant PWM: the motors follow their commands, and scipy's `solve_ivp` integrates the rigid body through `c4d.eqm.quadeqm`. The accelerometer reading is the body force of `c4d.eqm.quadforces` over the mass.

```
class QuadPlant(c4d.quatbody):
    """The vehicle: a quaternion rigid body that carries the
```

```
airframe parameters
    and its four motors.
    """

    def __init__(self, params, yaw0=0.0):
        super().__init__(psi=yaw0)  # NED / FRD state, at rest
on the ground
          for k, v in params.items(): # the vehicle carries
its parameters
            setattr(self, k, v)
        self.omega = np.zeros(4)    # rotor speeds [rad/s]
        self.specific_force = np.array([0.0, 0.0, -self.g])  #
what the accelerometer feels

    '''motors'''
    def motors(self, pwm, dt):
        u = (np.asarray(pwm) - 1000.0) / 1000.0
          e = np.clip((u - self.spin_min) / (self.spin_max -
self.spin_min), 0.0, 1.0)
        a = self.thrust_expo
         omega_cmd = self.omega_max * np.sqrt((1 - a) * e + a
* e**2)
          tau = np.where(omega_cmd > self.omega, self.tau_up,
self.tau_down)
          self.omega = omega_cmd + (self.omega - omega_cmd) *
np.exp(-dt / tau)

    '''rigid body'''
    def step(self, pwm, dt):
        self.motors(pwm, dt)
         F_b, _ = c4d.eqm.quadforces(self.X, self, self.omega,
'NED')
        self.specific_force = F_b / self.m
```

```
          sol = solve_ivp(c4d.eqm.quadeqm, [0.0, dt], self.X,
args=(self, self.omega, 'NED'))
        self.X = sol.y[:, -1]
          self.quat = self.quat # keep the quaternion a unit
quaternion

       if self.z >= 0 and self.vz >= 0: # on the ground: level
and at rest
            psi = self.psi
            self.z = self.vx = self.vy = self.vz = 0.0
            self.p = self.q = self.r = 0.0
            self.quat = c4d.rotmat.euler2quat(0.0, 0.0, psi)
            self.specific_force = c4d.rotmat.dcm321(psi=psi) @
[0.0, 0.0, -self.g]
```

3. Sensors

ArduCopter reads two things from the vehicle every fast-loop tick:

IMU — gyroscope and accelerometer.
The IMU is part of the flight controller: its sensor chips sit on the flight-controller board (the Pixhawk that the Iris carries), and ArduCopter reads them directly (not over MAVLink).

The simulation mounts the board at the vehicle's center of mass, aligned with the body axes (FRD), so the readings carry no lever-arm or misalignment terms. The gyroscope measures the body rates $[p, q, r]$. The accelerometer measures the *specific force* — the non-gravitational acceleration in the body frame, $\mathbf{f} = \mathbf{F}_b/m$. At rest it reads $-g$ on z (the ground pushes up); in hover it reads $\approx -g$ on z (the thrust pushes up).

$$\mathbf{z}_{gyro} = \boldsymbol{\omega} + \mathbf{b}_g + \mathbf{n}_g, \qquad \mathbf{z}_{acc} = \mathbf{f} + \mathbf{b}_a + \mathbf{n}_a$$

Inside the autopilot both pass through the 2-pole low-pass filters `INS_GYRO_FILTER` and `INS_ACCEL_FILTER` (20 Hz) before the controllers use them.

Navigation solution.
On a real vehicle $EKF3$ fuses the IMU with GPS, compass and barometer into attitude (a quaternion), position and velocity. This draft does not port $EKF3$: the navigation solution is the true state, with optional noise. This is the simulation's main simplification.

Sensor	Measures	White noise (1σ)	Initial bias (1σ)	Bias random walk	Rate
Gyroscope	p, q, r	$0.003\,rad/s$	$0.01\,rad/s$	$0.0002\,rad/s/\sqrt{s}$	$400\,Hz$
Accelerometer	f_x, f_y, f_z	$0.05\,m/s^2$	$0.15\,m/s^2$	$0.005\,m/s^2/\sqrt{s}$	$400\,Hz$
Navigation (EKF stand-in)	attitude quaternion, NED	0			$400\,Hz$

Sensor	Measures	White noise (1σ)	Initial bias (1σ)	Bias random walk	Rate
	position and velocity				

Each IMU axis carries a bias, drawn when the board powers up and then drifting as a random walk: $b_{k+1} = b_k + \sigma_{rw}\sqrt{\Delta t}\, n$. ArduPilot calibrates most of the initial bias away (gyro offsets at boot, accelerometer offsets in `INS_ACCOFFS`); the values here are an uncalibrated board, a worst case. Set `gyro_bias` and `accel_bias` to the residual to model a calibrated one.

Both come from the board: pixhawk.Pixhawk is the sensor kit of the simulation. `read_imu(vehicle)` returns the IMU sample, `read_nav(vehicle)` the navigation solution, and `read(vehicle)` both, in the order `ArduCopter.update(t, imu, nav)` takes them. The navigation attitude is the vehicle's quaternion, as in $EKF3$; its noise is a small body-frame rotation, and the autopilot derives φ, θ, ψ from it. The vehicle provides its true state (`X`, `quat`, `ang_rates`) and the specific force at its center of mass (`specific_force`).

The noise levels are the board's parameters:

```
# error model of the sensors on the Pixhawk board (1 sigma);
run() mounts a
# pixhawk.Pixhawk(**sensors) on the vehicle
sensors = {
    'gyro_std'  : 0.003,   # white noise [rad/s]
    'gyro_bias' : 0.01,    # initial bias [rad/s]
    'gyro_rw'   : 0.0002,  # bias random walk [rad/s/sqrt(s)]
    'accel_std' : 0.05,    # white noise [m/s^2]
    'accel_bias': 0.15,    # initial bias [m/s^2]
    'accel_rw'  : 0.005,   # bias random walk [m/s^2/sqrt(s)]
    'att_std'   : 0.0,     # navigation attitude [rad]
    'pos_std'   : 0.0,     # navigation position [m]
```

```
    'vel_std'   : 0.0,     # navigation velocity [m/s]
}
```

---

4. Main Loop

4.1. The Reference

The reference is the **Lissajous figure-8** of the Cascade-PID example, at a fixed altitude, in ENU:

$$x_{ref} = A\sin(\omega\tau), \qquad y_{ref} = B\sin(2\omega\tau), \qquad z_{ref} = h$$

Unlike the Cascade-PID example, the companion sends ArduPilot the velocity and acceleration as well — its position controller uses them as feedforward:

$$\begin{aligned}
\dot{x}_{ref} &= A\omega\cos(\omega\tau) \\
\dot{y}_{ref} &= 2B\omega\cos(2\omega\tau) \\
\ddot{x}_{ref} &= -A\omega^2\sin(\omega\tau) \\
\ddot{y}_{ref} &= -4B\omega^2\sin(2\omega\tau)
\end{aligned}$$

After one loop, a smooth return brings the vehicle back over the origin and down to $0.3\,m$.

```
trajectory = {
    'A'         : 4.0,    # figure-8 east amplitude [m]
    'B'         : 2.0,    # figure-8 north amplitude [m]
    'omega'      : 0.1,     # angular frequency [rad/s]  (one
loop ~ 62.8 s)
    'h'         : 5.0,    # flight altitude [m]
    'yaw'       : 0.0,    # heading, ENU [rad] (0 = facing east)
    't_hold'    : 2.0,    # hover after takeoff [s]
    't_return'   : 8.0,     # return to the origin and descend
to 0.3 m [s]
    'land_speed': 0.5,    # final descent rate [m/s]
}
```

```
def figure8(tau, tr):
    A, B, w, h = tr['A'], tr['B'], tr['omega'], tr['h']
     pos = np.array([A * np.sin(w * tau), B * np.sin(2 * w *
tau), h])
   vel = np.array([A * w * np.cos(w * tau), 2 * B * w * np.cos(2
* w * tau), 0.0])
    acc = np.array([-A * w**2 * np.sin(w * tau), -4 * B * w**2
* np.sin(2 * w * tau), 0.0])
    return pos, vel, acc


def go_home(tau, p_start, tr):
    s = np.clip(tau / tr['t_return'], 0, 1)
    p_end = np.array([0.0, 0.0, 0.3])
    pos = p_start + (p_end - p_start) * (3 * s**2 - 2 * s**3)
   vel = (p_end - p_start) * (6 * s - 6 * s**2) / tr['t_return']
    return pos, vel, np.zeros(3)
```

4.2. Frames at the MAVLink Boundary

ENU and NED swap x and y and flip z; a heading measured from east (ENU) becomes a heading measured from north (NED):

```
def enu2ned(v):
    return np.array([v[1], v[0], -v[2]])

ned2enu = enu2ned       # the same swap both ways


def yaw_enu2ned(yaw):
    return np.pi / 2 - yaw
```

4.3. The Mission

The companion computer runs the mission as a sequence of phases, each one the MAVLink step a real script would take:

Phase	Companion action	ArduPilot
preflight	`set_mode('GUIDED')`, `arm()`	motors at `MOT_SPIN_ARM`
takeoff	`takeoff(h)` (`MAV_CMD_NAV_TAKEOFF`)	jerk-limited climb at `WP_SPD_UP`, `WP_ACC_Z`
hold	position target at the origin	position hold
figure8	position + velocity + acceleration targets at 50 Hz	`GUIDED` pos-vel-accel control
return	smooth return to the origin, down to 0.3 m	
land	descend at 0.5 m/s through the ground	land detector → `land_complete`
disarmed	`disarm()`	motors stopped

4.4. The Loop

Every 2.5 ms tick, three things happen in order: the **companion** (every 8th tick, i.e. 50 Hz) updates the mission and sends targets, the **flight controller** reads the sensors and returns PWM, and the **vehicle** advances under that PWM.

`run()` flies one mission and returns the logged vehicle, the reference and the phase times. Its `wind` argument sets a constant wind vector in NED $[m/s]$; the drag of `c4d.eqm.quadforces` acts on the air-relative velocity (Section 6).

```
def run(ardupilot_params, trajectory, wind=None, t_max=120.0,
setpoint_rate=50.0, log_rate=50.0, seed=0, verbose=True):

    np.random.seed(seed)
    tr = trajectory

    copter = ardupilot.ArduCopter(ardupilot_params)
    plant  = QuadPlant(iris, yaw0=yaw_enu2ned(tr['yaw']))
    if wind is not None:
       plant.wind = np.asarray(wind, float)                    #
[m/s] NED, constant
```

```
    dt     = copter.dt                                                  #
1 / SCHED_LOOP_RATE
    board  = pixhawk.Pixhawk(dt=dt, **sensors)                          #
flight-controller board and its sensors
    sp_every  = int(round(copter.loop_rate_hz / setpoint_rate))
    log_every = int(round(copter.loop_rate_hz / log_rate))

    plant.pwm1 = plant.pwm2 = plant.pwm3 = plant.pwm4 = 0.0
    plant.hover = copter.motors.get_throttle_hover()
    ref = c4d.state(x=0.0, y=0.0, z=0.0) # commanded reference,
ENU

    yaw = yaw_enu2ned(tr['yaw'])
    t_fig8 = 2 * np.pi / tr['omega']
    phase, t_phase, events = 'preflight', 0.0, {}
    p_ref = np.zeros(3)

    copter.set_mode('GUIDED')
    copter.arm()

    for k in range(int(t_max / dt)):
        t = k * dt

        '''companion computer'''
        if k % sp_every == 0:

            if phase == 'preflight' and t >= 1.0:
                copter.takeoff(tr['h'])
                phase, t_phase = 'takeoff', t

            elif phase == 'takeoff':
                 # ArduPilot shapes the climb itself; log its
target as the reference
                                                        p_ref   =
```

```
ned2enu(copter.pos_control.get_pos_desired_NED_m())
                if copter.takeoff_complete():
                    phase, t_phase = 'hold', t

            elif phase == 'hold':
                p_ref = np.array([0.0, 0.0, tr['h']])

copter.set_position_target_local_ned(enu2ned(p_ref), yaw=yaw)
                if t - t_phase >= tr['t_hold']:
                    phase, t_phase = 'figure8', t

            elif phase == 'figure8':
                p_ref, v_ref, a_ref = figure8(min(t - t_phase,
t_fig8), tr)

copter.set_position_target_local_ned(enu2ned(p_ref),
enu2ned(v_ref), enu2ned(a_ref), yaw=yaw)
                if t - t_phase >= t_fig8:
                           phase, t_phase, p_exit = 'return',
t, p_ref.copy()

            elif phase == 'return':
                  p_ref, v_ref, a_ref = go_home(t - t_phase,
p_exit, tr)

copter.set_position_target_local_ned(enu2ned(p_ref),
enu2ned(v_ref), enu2ned(a_ref), yaw=yaw)
                if t - t_phase >= tr['t_return']:
                    phase, t_phase = 'land', t

            elif phase == 'land':
             p_ref = np.array([0.0, 0.0, 0.3 - tr['land_speed']
* (t - t_phase)])

copter.set_position_target_local_ned(enu2ned(p_ref),
enu2ned([0, 0, -tr['land_speed']]), yaw=yaw)
```

```
                if copter.land_complete:
                    copter.disarm()
                    phase, t_phase = 'disarmed', t

            elif phase == 'disarmed' and t - t_phase >= 1.0:
                break

            if phase not in events:
                events[phase] = t
                if verbose:
                    print(f't = {t:6.2f} s  ->  {phase}')

        '''flight controller'''
        pwm = copter.update(t, *board.read(plant))

        '''log'''
        if k % log_every == 0:
           plant.pwm1, plant.pwm2, plant.pwm3, plant.pwm4 = pwm
            plant.hover = copter.motors.get_throttle_hover()
            plant.store(t)
            plant.storeparams(['pwm1', 'pwm2', 'pwm3', 'pwm4',
'hover'], t=t)
            ref.X = p_ref
            ref.store(t)

        '''vehicle'''
        plant.step(pwm, dt)

    return plant, ref, events, copter
```

Run the mission:

```
body, ref, events, copter = run(ardupilot_params, trajectory)
print(f"learned                                    MOT_THST_HOVER
= {copter.motors.get_throttle_hover():.3f}")
```

```
t =   0.00 s  ->  preflight
t =   1.00 s  ->  takeoff
t =   5.52 s  ->  hold
t =   7.52 s  ->  figure8
t =  70.36 s  ->  return
t =  78.36 s  ->  land
t =  80.86 s  ->  disarmed
learned MOT_THST_HOVER = 0.612
```

---

5. Results

The state is stored in NED; for comparison with the reference it is converted back to ENU:

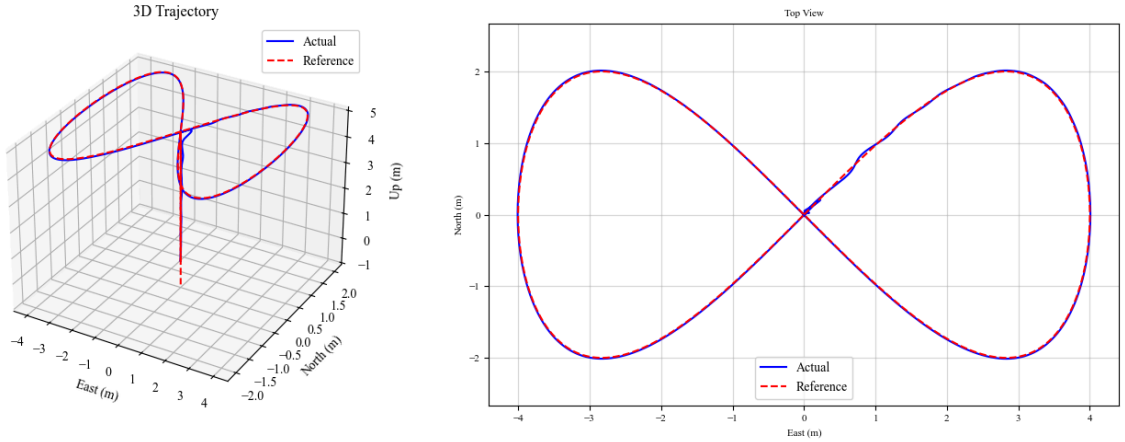
```
t   = body.data('x')[0]
pos = ned2enu(np.array([body.data('x')[1], body.data('y')[1],
body.data('z')[1]]))
pr       =    np.array([ref.data('x')[1],    ref.data('y')[1],
ref.data('z')[1]])
fig8_phase = (t >= events['figure8']) & (t < events['return'])
```

5.1. Trajectory

```
fig = plt.figure(figsize=(14, 5))

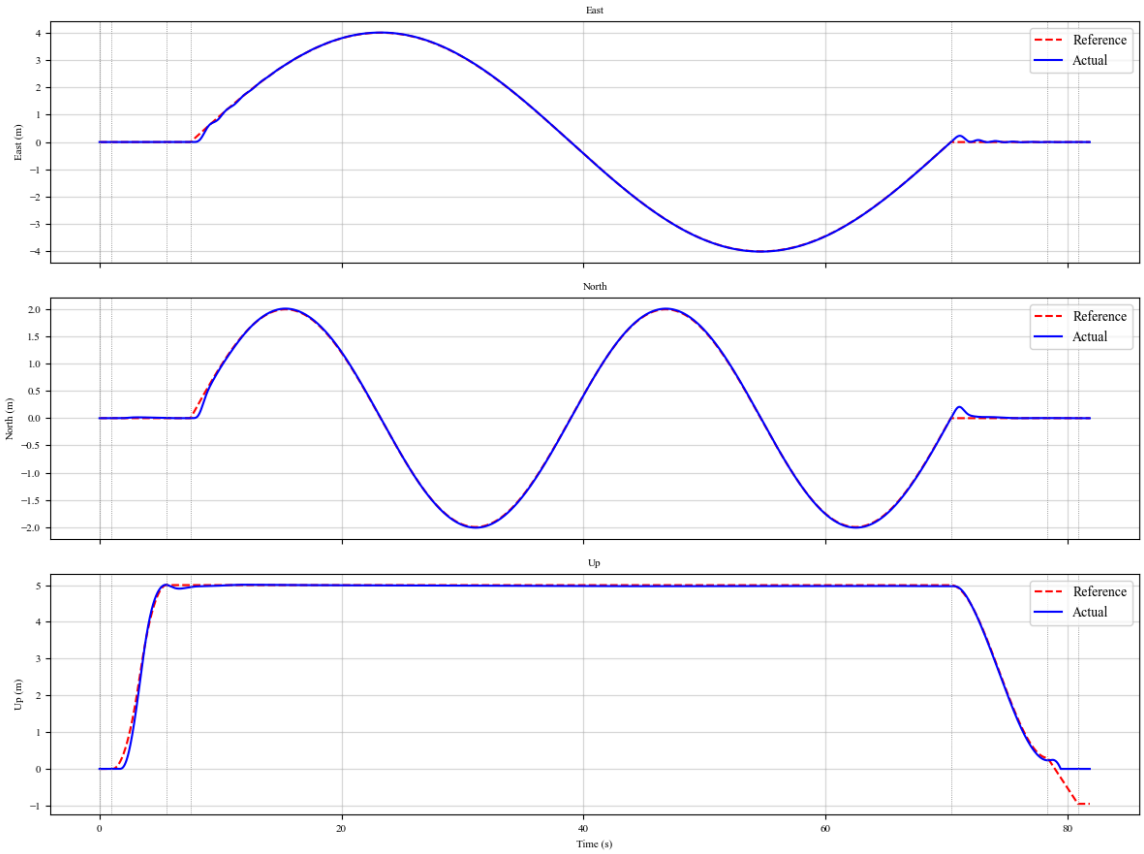
ax = fig.add_subplot(1, 2, 1, projection='3d')
ax.plot(*pos, 'b', lw=1.5, label='Actual')
ax.plot(*pr, 'r--', lw=1.5, label='Reference')
ax.set_xlabel('East    (m)');    ax.set_ylabel('North    (m)');
ax.set_zlabel('Up (m)')
ax.set_title('3D Trajectory'); ax.legend()

ax = fig.add_subplot(1, 2, 2)
ax.plot(pos[0], pos[1], 'b', lw=1.5, label='Actual')
ax.plot(pr[0], pr[1], 'r--', lw=1.5, label='Reference')
c4d.plotdefaults(ax,  'Top  View',  'East  (m)',  'North  (m)',
fontsize = 10)
ax.axis('equal'); ax.legend()
plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()
```



5.2. Tracking

```
fig, ax = plt.subplots(3, 1, figsize=(12, 9), sharex=True)
for i, name in enumerate(['East', 'North', 'Up']):
    ax[i].plot(t, pr[i], 'r--', lw=1.5, label='Reference')
    ax[i].plot(t, pos[i], 'b', lw=1.5, label='Actual')
     c4d.plotdefaults(ax[i], name, '', f'{name} (m)', fontsize
= 10)
    ax[i].legend(loc='upper right')
ax[2].set_xlabel('Time (s)')
for a in ax:
    for ph, te in events.items():
        a.axvline(te, color='gray', lw=0.6, ls=':')
plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()
```



The dotted lines mark the mission phases. During the takeoff the reference is ArduPilot's own shaped climb profile (`WP_SPD_UP` $= 2.5\,m/s$, `WP_ACC_Z` $= 1\,m/s^2$). In the final descent the reference goes below the ground on purpose — the vehicle lands, the land detector sees the motors at their lower limit with no vertical motion for $1\,s$, and the companion disarms.

5.3. Metrics

Root-mean-square error of the true position against the commanded reference, over the figure-8 phase:

```
def metrics(t, pos, pr, idx, tr):
    err = pos[:, idx] - pr[:, idx]
    rmse = np.sqrt(np.mean(err**2, axis=1))
    print('=' * 52)
    print('   TRACKING PERFORMANCE  (figure-8 phase)')
```

```
    print('=' * 52)
    print(f"  RMSE east  : {rmse[0]:.4f} m   ({rmse[0] / tr['A']
* 100:.2f}% of A)")
    print(f"  RMSE north : {rmse[1]:.4f} m   ({rmse[1] / tr['B']
* 100:.2f}% of B)")
    print(f"  RMSE up    : {rmse[2]:.4f} m   ({rmse[2] / tr['h']
* 100:.2f}% of h)")
        print(f"   max  3D  err  :  {np.max(np.linalg.norm(err,
axis=0)):.4f} m")
    print('=' * 52)
    return rmse

rmse = metrics(t, pos, pr, fig8_phase, trajectory)
```

```
====================================================
   TRACKING PERFORMANCE  (figure-8 phase)
====================================================
  RMSE east  : 0.0250 m   (0.62% of A)
  RMSE north : 0.0247 m   (1.23% of B)
  RMSE up    : 0.0224 m   (0.45% of h)
  max 3D err : 0.3081 m
====================================================
```

ArduCopter tracks the figure-8 to a few centimetres. Two things make this possible, both part of ArduPilot's design: the companion sends velocity and acceleration feedforward with every target, and the position controller shapes the commanded path with jerk limits before tracking it, so the vehicle is never asked for more than it can do.

5.4. Attitude and Motors

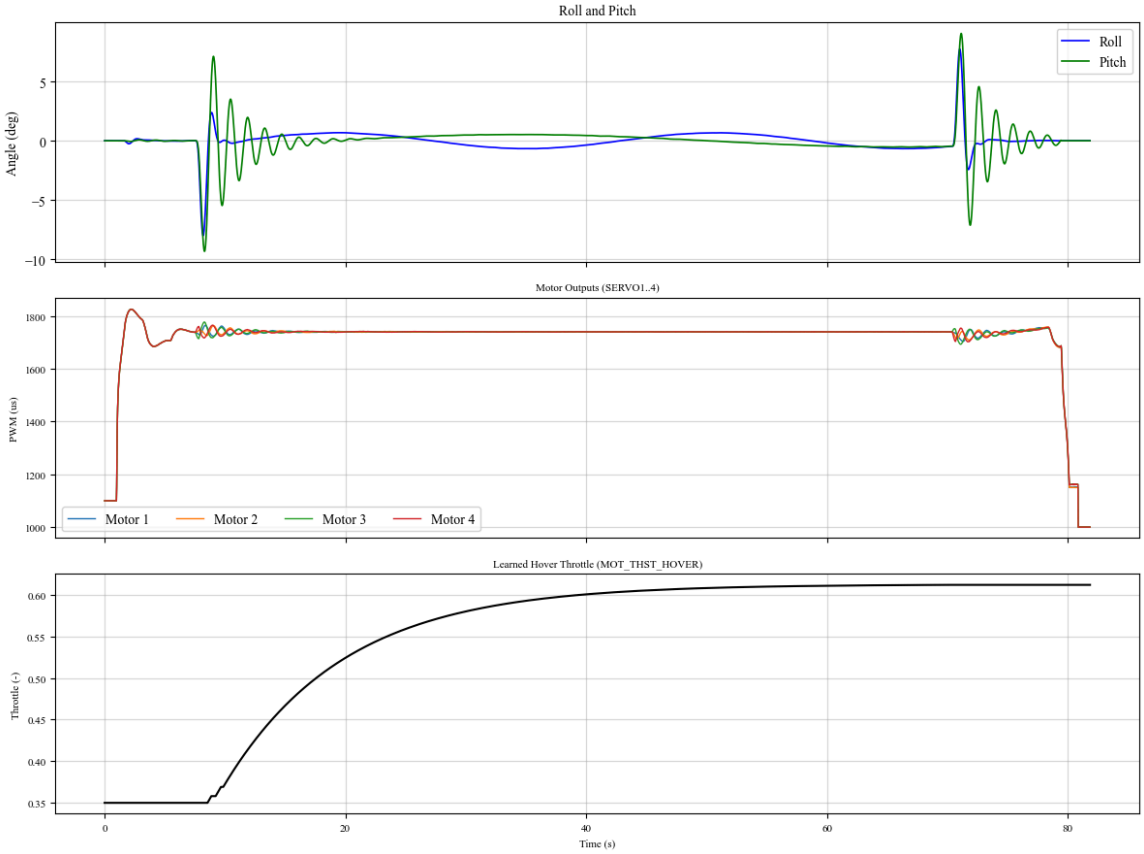
```
fig, ax = plt.subplots(3, 1, figsize=(12, 9), sharex=True)

ax[0].plot(t,  body.data('phi',  c4d.r2d)[1],  'b',  lw=1.2,
```

```
label='Roll')
ax[0].plot(t, body.data('theta', c4d.r2d)[1], 'g', lw=1.2,
label='Pitch')
c4d.plotdefaults(ax[0], 'Roll and Pitch', '', 'Angle (deg)',
fontsize = 10)
ax[0].legend()

for i in range(1, 5):
      ax[1].plot(*body.data(f'pwm{i}'), lw=1.0, label=f'Motor
{i}')
c4d.plotdefaults(ax[1], 'Motor Outputs (SERVO1..4)', '', 'PWM
(us)', fontsize = 10)
ax[1].legend(ncol=4)

ax[2].plot(*body.data('hover'), 'k', lw=1.5)
c4d.plotdefaults(ax[2],      'Learned      Hover      Throttle
(MOT_THST_HOVER)', 'Time (s)', 'Throttle (-)', fontsize = 10)
plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()
```



- **Hover throttle.** `MOT_THST_HOVER` starts at ArduCopter's default 0.35 and converges to ≈ 0.61 — the Iris's true hover thrust fraction (Section 2.4). Until it converges, the vertical acceleration controller's integrator carries the difference.
- **Pitch ringing.** Where the figure-8 starts and where the return starts, the pitch rings at about 0.7 Hz for several cycles. This is a real finding, not a numerical artifact: the default rate gains are under-tuned for this airframe. The Iris model produces only $\approx 34\,rad/s^2$ of pitch acceleration per unit of rate-controller output, so with the default `ATC_RAT_PIT_P` $= 0.135$ the rate loop is slower than the angle loop above it.

5.5. Changing a Parameter

This is what the simulator is for: change a parameter, fly again, compare. Raising the roll and pitch rate gains by a factor of 3, as a tuning pass (or ArduCopter's `AUTOTUNE`) would do:

```
tuned = {}
for axis in ['RLL', 'PIT']:
                    tuned[f'ATC_RAT_{axis}_P']     =     3     *
copter.params[f'ATC_RAT_{axis}_P']
                    tuned[f'ATC_RAT_{axis}_I']     =     3     *
copter.params[f'ATC_RAT_{axis}_I']
                    tuned[f'ATC_RAT_{axis}_D']     =     3     *
copter.params[f'ATC_RAT_{axis}_D']
print(tuned)

body2, ref2, events2, _ = run(tuned, trajectory, verbose=False)
```

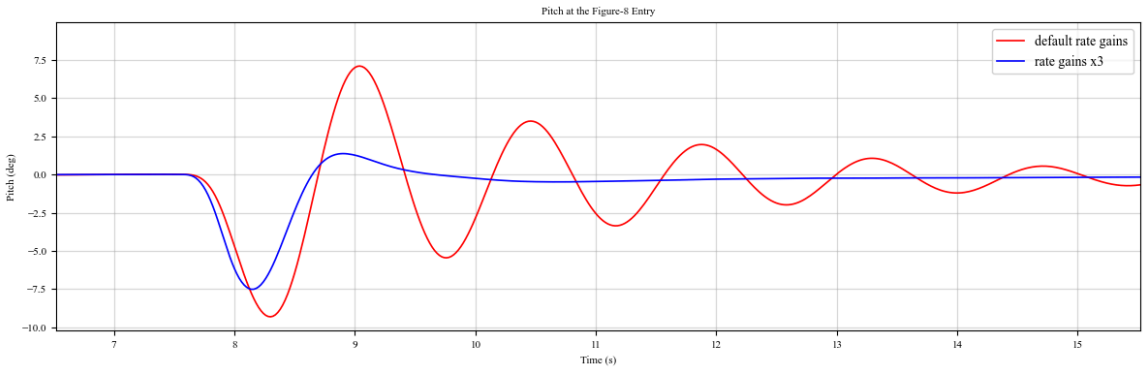
```
{'ATC_RAT_RLL_P':      0.405,      'ATC_RAT_RLL_I':      0.405,
'ATC_RAT_RLL_D':     0.0108,      'ATC_RAT_PIT_P':      0.405,
'ATC_RAT_PIT_I': 0.405, 'ATC_RAT_PIT_D': 0.0108}
```

```
t2 = body2.data('x')[0]

fig, ax = plt.subplots(1, 1, figsize=(12, 4))
ax.plot(t,   body.data('theta',   c4d.r2d)[1],   'r',   lw=1.2,
label='default rate gains')
ax.plot(t2,  body2.data('theta',  c4d.r2d)[1],  'b',  lw=1.2,
label='rate gains x3')
c4d.plotdefaults(ax, 'Pitch at the Figure-8 Entry', 'Time (s)',
'Pitch (deg)', fontsize = 10)
ax.set_xlim(events['figure8'] - 1, events['figure8'] + 8)
ax.legend()
plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()

pos2  =  ned2enu(np.array([body2.data('x')[1],  body2.data('y')
[1], body2.data('z')[1]]))
pr2      =   np.array([ref2.data('x')[1],   ref2.data('y')[1],
```

```
ref2.data('z')[1]])
rmse2 = metrics(t2, pos2, pr2, (t2 >= events2['figure8']) & (t2
< events2['return']), trajectory)
```




```
======================================================
   TRACKING PERFORMANCE  (figure-8 phase)
======================================================
  RMSE east  : 0.0234 m   (0.59% of A)
  RMSE north : 0.0246 m   (1.23% of B)
  RMSE up    : 0.0225 m   (0.45% of h)
  max 3D err : 0.2856 m
======================================================
```

With the faster rate loop the pitch oscillation is damped within about one cycle instead of ringing for several seconds. The position RMSE barely changes — the position controller hid the problem in the tracking numbers, and only the attitude shows it. The remaining transient comes from the figure-8 entry itself: the reference velocity jumps from hover to $0.57\,m/s$ there.

---

6. Wind Sweep

A simulation written entirely in Python makes a new flight condition cheap: one argument, one more flight, no hardware and no SITL setup. It can therefore answer statistical questions that a single flight cannot. *How does the stock tuning hold up in wind, and from which direction does wind hurt most?*

The mission and the parameters stay the same. Only the air moves: a constant wind of 4, 8 and 12 m/s, from each of 8 compass directions, makes 24 flights, plus the calm-air flight of Section 4. The direction is where the wind blows *from*, as in a weather report (0° = from the north). The drag of the Iris model is linear, so the steady wind force is $A_x V$: 3.6 N at 12 m/s, a lean of $\arctan(3.6/mg) \approx 14°$ just to hold position.

⏱ Each flight takes about a minute on a laptop. The flights are independent, so joblib flies them in parallel, one process per CPU core: on 4 cores the sweep runs in about a quarter of the time. For a quick look, shorten `speeds` or `directions`.

```
from joblib import Parallel, delayed


def wind_ned(speed, direction):
   """Wind of `speed` [m/s] blowing FROM the compass `direction`
[deg] (0 = from north), in NED."""
    d = np.radians(direction)
    return -speed * np.array([np.cos(d), np.sin(d), 0.0])


def fig8_stats(body, ref, events):
     """Tracking statistics of one flight, over the figure-8
phase."""
    t   = body.data('x')[0]
```

```
    pos = ned2enu(np.array([body.data('x')[1], body.data('y')
[1], body.data('z')[1]]))
       pr    =  np.array([ref.data('x')[1],  ref.data('y')[1],
ref.data('z')[1]])
    idx = (t >= events['figure8']) & (t < events['return'])
    err = pos[:, idx] - pr[:, idx]
    phi, theta = body.data('phi')[1][idx], body.data('theta')
[1][idx]
   return {'rmse_h'  : np.sqrt(np.mean(err[0]**2 + err[1]**2)),
# horizontal RMSE [m]
                    'rmse_up'  :  np.sqrt(np.mean(err[2]**2)),
# vertical RMSE [m]
             'max_err' : np.max(np.linalg.norm(err, axis=0)),
# max 3D error [m]
                  'max_tilt':  np.max(np.arccos(np.cos(phi)  *
np.cos(theta))) * c4d.r2d}  # max tilt [deg]


def flight(s, d):
   """One flight in a wind of `s` [m/s] from `d` [deg]; returns
its statistics."""
       b,  r,  ev,  _  =  run(ardupilot_params,  trajectory,
wind=wind_ned(s, d), verbose=False)
    return fig8_stats(b, r, ev)


speeds     = [4, 8, 12]                  # [m/s]
directions = np.arange(0, 360, 45)       # [deg], wind from N,
NE, E, ...
cases      = [(s, d) for s in speeds for d in directions]

# the flights are independent: fly them in parallel, one process
per CPU core
results = Parallel(n_jobs=-1, verbose=10)(delayed(flight)(s, d)
```

```
for s, d in cases)

stats = {(0, 0): fig8_stats(body, ref, events)}     # calm air:
the flight of Section 4
stats.update(zip(cases, results))
```

For each flight, the horizontal and vertical $RMSE$ over the figure-8 phase, the maximum 3D error and the maximum tilt $\arccos(\cos\varphi\cos\theta)$:

```
%matplotlib widget

fig = plt.figure(figsize=(15, 5.5))
th = np.radians(np.append(directions, directions[0]))       #
close the polar curves
colors = plt.cm.viridis(np.linspace(0.15, 0.85, len(speeds)))
angle_max = copter.params['ATC_ANGLE_MAX']

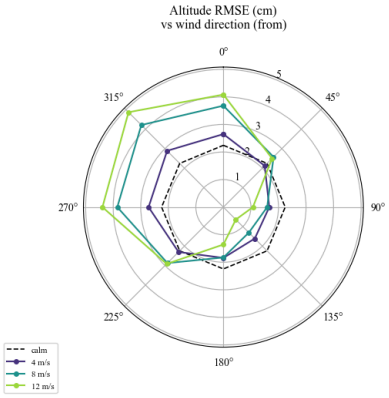
for j, (key, scale, title) in enumerate([('rmse_up', 100,
'Altitude RMSE (cm)'), ('max_tilt', 1, 'Max Tilt (deg)')]):
    ax = fig.add_subplot(1, 3, j + 1, projection='polar')
   ax.set_theta_zero_location('N'); ax.set_theta_direction(-1)
# compass: N up, clockwise
     ax.plot(th, np.full(th.shape, stats[0, 0][key] * scale),
'k--', lw=1.2, label='calm')
    for s, col in zip(speeds, colors):
        v = [stats[s, d][key] * scale for d in directions]
      ax.plot(th, np.append(v, v[0]), 'o-', color=col, lw=1.5,
ms=4, label=f'{s} m/s')
    if key == 'max_tilt':
         ax.plot(np.linspace(0, 2 * np.pi, 100), np.full(100,
angle_max), 'r:', lw=1.5, label='ATC_ANGLE_MAX')
    ax.set_title(f'{title}\nvs wind direction (from)', pad=18)
    ax.set_rlim(0, None)
    ax.legend(loc='lower left', bbox_to_anchor=(-0.3, -0.18),
```

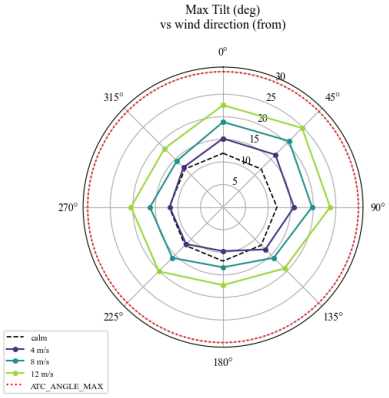
```
fontsize=8)

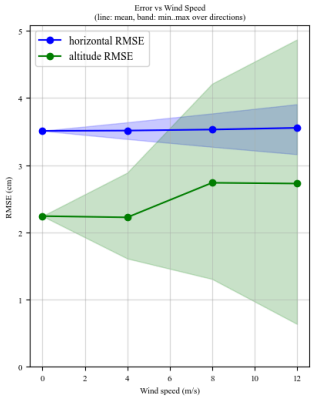
ax = fig.add_subplot(1, 3, 3)
for key, col, lab in [('rmse_h', 'b', 'horizontal RMSE'),
('rmse_up', 'g', 'altitude RMSE')]:
    calm = stats[0, 0][key] * 100
    v = np.array([[stats[s, d][key] for d in directions] for s
in speeds]) * 100
    ax.plot([0] + speeds, [calm] + list(v.mean(axis=1)), 'o-',
color=col, label=lab)
   ax.fill_between([0] + speeds, [calm] + list(v.min(axis=1)),
[calm] + list(v.max(axis=1)), color=col, alpha=0.2)
c4d.plotdefaults(ax, 'Error vs Wind Speed\n(line: mean, band:
min..max over directions)', 'Wind speed (m/s)', 'RMSE (cm)',
fontsize = 10)
ax.set_ylim(0, None)
ax.legend()
plt.tight_layout()
plt.show()

print(f"{'wind':>8s} | {'RMSE horiz (cm)':>15s} | {'RMSE up
(cm)':>21s} | {'max err (cm)':>12s} | {'max tilt (deg)':>20s}")
print(f"{'':>8s}  |  {'min':>7s}  {'max':>7s}  |  {'min':>6s}
{'max':>6s}  {'from':>7s}  |  {'max':>12s}  |  {'max':>12s}
{'from':>7s}")
print('-' * 92)
for s in [0] + speeds:
    ds  = [0] if s == 0 else list(directions)
    col = lambda key: np.array([stats[s, d][key] for d in ds])
          frm  =  lambda  key:  '-'  if  s  ==  0  else
f'{ds[int(np.argmax(col(key)))]:3d} deg'
      print(f"{s:4d} m/s | {col('rmse_h').min() * 100:7.2f}
{col('rmse_h').max() * 100:7.2f} | "
                      f"{col('rmse_up').min()  *  100:6.2f}
```

```
{col('rmse_up').max() * 100:6.2f} {frm('rmse_up'):>7s} | "
                    f"{col('max_err').max()  *  100:12.1f}  |
{col('max_tilt').max():12.1f} {frm('max_tilt'):>7s}")
```








```
    wind | RMSE horiz (cm) |          RMSE up (cm) | max err
(cm) |       max tilt (deg)
         |     min     max |    min    max    from |         max
|          max    from
-------------------------------------------------------------------------------
   0 m/s |    3.51    3.51 |   2.24   2.24       - |        30.8
|         11.9       -
   4 m/s |    3.39    3.64 |   1.61   2.89 315 deg |        31.6
|         16.4  45 deg
   8 m/s |    3.27    3.77 |   1.31   4.21 315 deg |        32.4
|         20.7  45 deg
  12 m/s |    3.16    3.91 |   0.64   4.87 315 deg |        33.2
|         24.8  45 deg
```

- **Horizontal tracking does not care about the wind.** Over all 24 flights the horizontal $RMSE$ stays between 3.2 and 3.9 cm (calm: 3.5 cm). A steady wind is a constant disturbance, and the integrator of the velocity PID (`PSC_NE_VEL_I`) removes it. The maximum 3D error (31–33 cm) also barely moves, because it comes from the figure-8 entry (Section 5.5), not from the wind.

- **Altitude depends on the direction.** The vertical $RMSE$ ranges from $0.6\,cm$ to $4.9\,cm$ at $12\,m/s$: about twice the calm value with wind from the north-west, a third of it with wind from the south-east. Averaged over directions, the effect almost disappears. A single test flight in one wind would therefore give a misleading number in either direction. Only the sweep shows the spread.
- **The tilt margin is what wind consumes.** The maximum tilt grows from 12° in calm air to 25° at $12\,m/s$ from the north-east, against the 30° of `ATC_ANGLE_MAX`. North-east is the direction the figure-8 starts toward, so there the entry manoeuvre and the lean into the wind add up. The steady lean ($\approx 14^\circ$ at $12\,m/s$) plus the entry transient ($\approx 11^\circ$) accounts for it. By the same estimate the angle limit is reached at about $17\,m/s$. Beyond that, the vehicle can no longer hold the path, however good the tracking numbers look below it.

The same loop works for any other condition: sweep `seed` for the sensor-noise statistics, `sensors['gyro_bias']` for an uncalibrated board, `iris['m']` for payload, or any ArduPilot parameter.

---

7. Summary

- A companion-computer main loop, a Python port of the ArduCopter 4.7.1 control stack, and a c4dynamics rigid-body vehicle make a closed simulation loop with the same interfaces as the real drone: MAVLink-style targets in, sensor samples in, PWM out.
- In `GUIDED` mode, with stock parameters, ArduCopter tracks the figure-8 to a few centimetres, learns the hover throttle in flight, detects the landing and disarms.
- On the Iris model, the stock rate gains are slow, and the pitch rings. This is exactly the kind of finding the simulator is for. Change the parameter here first, then on the vehicle.
- A wind sweep of 24 flights shows that the stock tuning holds the horizontal path to $\approx 3.5\,cm$ in winds up to $12\,m/s$. What the wind takes is altitude accuracy, depending on its direction, and tilt margin: 25° of the 30° limit at $12\,m/s$.

Next steps. Port $EKF3$ so the autopilot flies on fused GPS / IMU / compass / barometer measurements instead of the true state. Then add ArduCopter's `LAND` and `AUTO` modes, and a real MAVLink interface so an unmodified companion script can drive the simulation.